"STAR O' RABBIE BURNS"

Anniversary Celebration in Shanghai: Dr. Couper Patrick's Eulogy

Owing to the belated formation of the Shanghai Burns Club, it was not possible for the members to have their particular celebration on "Burns Nicht" (the 175th anniversary of which occurred on Thursday), but they gave their patronage to the charity concert held that night and arranged their own dinner for on Friday night at the Astor House Hotel. With so little time for recruitment, naturally it was a comparatively small gathering, but the enthusiasm was great and promised wonderful times in years to come. Even a misunderstanding which led to the absence of a piper—and so a lessening of the honours due to "The Haggis"—and the misconception of what constitutes "tatties an 'herrin'" failed to dampen the enthusiasm.

Dr. H. Couper Patrick proved an excellent inaugural President. He opened by referring to the Burns Nicht Concert, which not only was greatly enjoyed by all who attended, but yielded a substantial profit for the British Unemployed Fund, and then paid a tribute to Mrs. Wm. Lyle, who so pluckily carried on with the management of that concert, and her husband, who did the same with the Burns Club dinner, though so shortly before those functions they suffered a sad loss in the death of their sister-in-law. On behalf of the members, he expressed their sympathy with Mr. John Lyle and Mr. and Mrs. Wm. Lyle.

A Presentation Portrait

Mr. Wm. Lyle then presented to the club a portrait of Burns painted by his sister-in-law, to which she was just putting the finishing touches when she contracted the affection which brought about her death. It is a really clever piece of work, a true likeness, and beautifully coloured, and was much admired by the company.

Dr. Patrick proceeded with the toast of "The Immortal Memory of Rabbie Burns." He mentioned that, at the last Burns dinner held in Shanghai, thirty years ago, "Wullie Brewed a Peck o' Maut" was sung by a trio, two of whom were present that evening as members of the new club—Messrs. W. S. Burns and C. M. Bain. He continued with an eloquent address on the life of Burns, breaking off at times to give samples of his poems. His general purpose was to show that, admitting what might in these days be considered grave failings, these in Burns were outweighed by his obvious virtues, and on the balance he was well worthy the place he held in Scottish hearts. Considerations on space compel condensation, but extracts from the address follow:—

A Popular Misconception

Burns' attendances in the only social clubhouse that existed in the village life of his time, the tavern, have been made to obscure the truth that he was indeed as the average sober man of his class, and not at all in that aspect of social life to be compared with the very hard-drinking gentry into whose company his genius brought him. Close study of the facts of his life has made it plain that the poet's song in praise of wine and whiskey cannot justly be made to carry the record of the daily habit of his life.

Home-brewed ale, whiskey at 10d. a quart and equally cheap claret had no rivals in tea from 15s. to 30s. a pound, or coffee at 7s. 6d. and chocolate at 3s. 6d., and these were little known and not much liked in the Scotland of Burns' day, certainly not with the peasantry or the plain folk of the towns. So Burns drank as did his neighbours and the definite testimony of those who knew him was that he was no hard drinker.

Till manhood moving in the poorest and most secluded circles of country life in a land that knew no wealth, Burns had the faults of his surroundings and added to them the character belonging to a personality that abounded in the strongest feelings and passions untamed by conventionality. That the record of his life shows many blots is but to say that every time the turbulent river of his manhood burst its banks the destruction and sorrow which its overflow had caused was written down and placarded to all time. Of no man who has written the tale of the thoughts and feelings of the human heart has there been displayed to all the world the blunders and sins of his own frailty as with Burns. We need make no apology for Burns, but it is well worth our while that we should try to understand him. After his time of triumph in Edinburgh, and his tours through Scotland, there came a pause and the need to adjust himself to a new phase of life.

Volunteer Honours

In the early part of 1795, when the Dumfrieshire Corps of Volunteers was embodied, Burns became one of the original members and wrote for it his famous song beginning "Does haughty Gaul invasion threat?" and closing "But while we sing 'God save the King,' we'll ne'er forget the people." It is said of this song that "it hit the taste and suited the feelings of the humbler classes. Hills echoed with it; it was heard in every street, and did more to right the mind of the rustic part of the population than all the speeches of Pitt and Dundas, or the chosen Five-and-Forty (Members of Parliament) from Scotland." About fifteen months later, the Gentlemen Volunteers of Dumfries carried the mortal remains of Robert Burns to the grave with military honours.

He was a most painstaking worker, and, great as was his genius, no less great was he in all the laborious task of sifting out material that existed in dance-music and in the folk-song of Scotland, and in weaving that with his own poetic work into a great body of national song of unequalled beauty anywhere. J. C. Dick wrote that Burns discovered many traditional melodies in his excursions through Scotland, and was the means of getting the notation printed, thus preserving a considerable collection of folk music which otherwise would have perished. Scotland is as much indebted to Robert Burns for the perpetuation of its music as it is for its lyrics."

The Supreme Artist

Of the 250 songs of his own that Burns contributed to the editions of Johnson and Thomson, besides others that he collected in the last five years of his life, a few of the greatest were:—"The Lea Rig," "Duncan Gray," "Scots Wha Hae," "O Whistle and I'll Come to Ye, My Lad," "Highland Mary," "Ca' the Yowes to the Knowes," "A Man's a Man for a' That." With these songs and all the others before us surely we can agree with a recent critic, Alexander Keith of Aberdeen, when he claims that there has been error in looking on Burns the peasant prodigy, the ploughman poet, in his own phrase "Rantin,' Rovin' Robin"; that we should rather esteem his as the supreme artist in his own field of music in verse. His talent of aesthetic intuition,, his command of artistic technique won by the long hours of patient study and work under the guidance of his spirit of genius, and the universality of his human sympathy—these have placed him in the foremost rank of the poet singers of the world. "On Burns' poetry, as on the literature of ancient Greece, there are no two opinions; he is, at his highest, perfection—a perfection in its sublimity and sustained humanity altogether unique in English literature," said Keith.

Dr. Patrick concluded:—"So let us leave him, with all that was little in him forgotten in the greatness of his humanity, and happily cherishing an enduring memory of the man and the singer; Scotland's dearest and best—Immortal Rabbie Burns.

"Th' Land o' Cakes"

Mr. Ranald G. McDonald, President of St. Andrew's Society, followed with the toast of "Th' Land o' Cakes." Unable to divorce himself from the sentiment of the evening, Mr. McDonald substituted for a eulogy of his native land one of Scotland's second favourite and effectively quoted John Drinkwater's summary of Burns' qualities:—

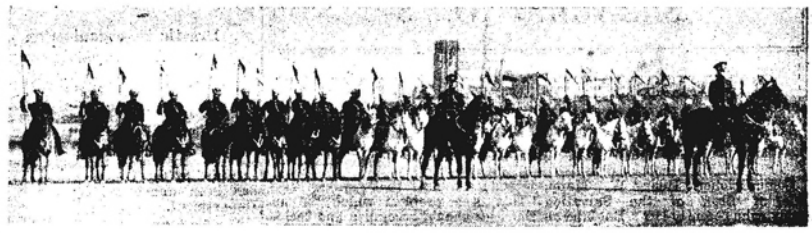
"Passionate love of country; genuine sympathy with all animate things; emotional response to nature in every mood and aspect; revolt against anciently accepted bonds—religious, social, and political; fearless independence; a clairvoyant sense of all that is implied in racial sentiment; unaffected and masterly use of the vernacular speech, and the power to combine the loftiest reflections with true wit and humour. These are the qualities in Burns that put him first among all creative artists in the hearts of Scottish people."

"The Lassies"

There was one more toast—that of "The Lassies," which was left to the capable eloquence of Mr. H. E. D. Adams for proposal and Mr. W. Alston Turnbull for response. In the circumstances, it was a pity there were no "lassies" present, for they would have enjoyed the robust speech of their champion and no less the arch response of their supporter, both of whom acquitted themselves as true squires of dames.

A thoroughly enjoyable evening, and a truly loyal Scottish one—with no objections from the handfull of Irish, English, and American admirers of Burns who were included—was rounded out with musical contributions from Messrs. J. K. Scobie, H. Wallace, and A. P. Stoner, all of whom were in great form, particularly Mr. Scobie, with whom "The Star o' Rabbie Burns" is becoming a local classic. Splendid assistance was given by the hotel orchestra, who, though foreign to the Scottish music, played it with all the vigour with which their hearers accepted it.

POLICE MOUNTED UNIT ON PARADE



The Mounted Unit of the Shanghai Municipal Police on parade at the Racecourse on Friday.

"BURNS NICHT CONCERT" IN THE EMBASSY

Shanghai faded far, far into the Background on Thursday night at the Embassy Theatre where the Shanghai Burns Club conjured forth the finest and best of Scottish tradition in honour of the 175th anniversary of Robert Burns's birth. Clamorous applause greeted pipers and dancers, and called for encores from elocutionists and soloists on the excellent programme of music, dancing and humour arranged to celebrate, in true Scottish fashion, the birth of the most beloved of Scotland's poets.

With the initial number of the Band of the 2nd Battn. The Worcestershire Regiment, the concert was under way to familiar melodies introducing such favourites as "Auld Robin Gray," Bonnie Laddie", "the Campbells are Coming", and a dozen other tunes in a well-planned medley, "Gems of Scotland". A group of pipe selections drew a barrage of approval. Pipe-Major J. Wellsted led Pipers W. M. MacLennan, J. D. Riddle, W. Todd, and Miss Barbara Mills in their spirited version of Pipe Marches, Strathspey, and Reel, Mr. J. Scobie scored in vocal solos, and Mrs. P. Longden enthralled her audience with a cleverly interpreted excerpt from Sir James Barrie's "A Window in Thrums."

Ten young pupils of Miss Sharp presented an interesting Broadsword Dance, followed by a vocal solo by Mrs. H. W. P. McMeekin, whose "Annie Laurie" evoked two encores. Master Ronald Malcolm, boy soprano, nearly succeeded in stopping the show with his superb rendering of "Bonnie Mary o' Argyle." But if enthusiasm ran high on previous occasions, it burst forth in acclaim when Miss Barbara Mills, Miss Jessie Kliene, Mr. W. M. MacLennan and Mr.. H.K. Strachan presented a Strathspey and Reel. All excellent dancers, they failed in their attempt to be excused with a bow, and were recalled for an encore which was given but not repeated, though lusty shouts for still more effectively stopped the performance for a full three minutes.

Clad in fisher costume, Mrs. P. D. G. Gain likewise was treated to an ovation after her songs, while Mrs. Mervyn Cox's "Impm-n" was another signal for applause. Miss Mills, Mr. H. Wallace, Mr. Kenneth Mackenzie and the pipers, completed an evening thoroughly distinctive.

A portrait of Robert Burns was in the centre of the stage-curtain, while crests of Scottish clans were used to decorate the theatre, imparting to the whole an atmosphere truly in keeping with the gaiety of "Burns Night" celebrated that wherever Scotsmen gathered. The proceeds will be donated to the British Unemployment Fund.—D.L.G.

A radio appeal for the building campaign of the National Leprosarium of China, Shanghai, was made on Thursday night by Dr. F. Reiss, who broadcasted sketched the general problem before the public, and left its details as regards Shanghai to Dr. F. Reiss, who is broadcasting over the same station the next night.

NEW HOME FOR 60 BABIES IN FRENCH TOWN

Excellent Work by Ecole Remi Creche

Persistently falling snow and a bleak wind from the river had no unpleasant effects on the snug, many-windowed playroom of the newly opened Ecole Remi creche, where scores of youngsters in sedate blue and white pinafores were amusing themselves in scores of different ways. The youngest was not quite two, the eldest had not reached six.

Secure in the enviable detachment of contented childhood, Katherine, black-eyed and vivacious, her little heart-shaped face faintly flushed with pleasure, bent over a huge baby doll in a long white dress, crooning a tuneless lullaby. She was quite oblivious to all the others around her. On other days, she is less docile, her alert brain on the lookout for diversions. One afternoon she carefully screwed off all the radiator caps, working so swiftly that the deed was done before anyone noticed.

On the other hand, Paul was playing the mounted knight for the audible edification of an enthusiastic audience, rocking furiously away to the scene of battle on a great white charger that made its most welcome appearance in the playroom at Christmastime. Stocky, apple-cheeked, he is a pleasing product of months at the creche, where wholesome food and sensible hours prevail.

In Make Belief

Four domestic-minded little girls gathered around the red and white playhouse that stands beneath the windows at the further end of the long room, a thoroughly satisfactory accessory to make-believe since it is almost as tall as the young ladies themselves. Tania, in her quaint lavender-coloured dress, her blonde braids wound with scarlet ribbons, was the leader, displaying the initiative of four years.

Quite alone on a bench sat Peter, the newest arrival of them all. For each day brings additional children to the creche, so that the present total is sixty, with a possible eighty accommodation. Only three and a half, Peter is faced with the overpowering problem of making a place for himself in a strange new world. And he is badly equipped for the venture.

A few weeks ago, the "little new boy" and his family—father, mother and an older brother of eight—lived in a tiny house in the Chinese city. The mother had steady employment while the father, badly crippled, found occasional odd jobs. Then the mother fell ill, Chinese neighbours sent in food to help out, and life went on until the black day when she died. The family was destitute until the authorities sent word to the Ecole Remi. So Paul, shyly proud of his stout brown shoes, is installed in the creche and his brother attends the school. But, knowing only a little Russian, for his companions were few, he has not learned to play—yet.

Formerly situated in Avenue Dubail, the creche was formally opened in its new quarters in connection with the Ecole Remi on January 13 with a tea and programme by the children. The latter, which showed excellent instruction and was cleverly costumed, will be repeated at the school on January 28 and will be open to the public. The creche is supported by the Caisse des Oeuvres. Mme. Mourier, the wife of the French Consul-General, is the president, while Mrs. O. G. Karmiloff is the secretary and Mrs. E. A. Kolouenine, formerly of the Red Cross, is in practical charge.

The Daily Nap

In the majority of instances, the children stay at the school only during the day. As soon as they arrive at eight breakfast is served, a very substantial meal in this winter weather. For the older ones, there is morning kindergarten and for the younger play indoors or long walks in fine weather. Dinner is promptly at twelve and then every child, even the one who has attained the vast age of five and a half, sleeps until half-past two. There are no exceptions to this wise rule. Tea at three and supper at six end the day.

The fourteen who are "boarders" occupy a spic and span nursery on the second floor, where a quiet-faced madonna looked down from her gilt frame on fourteen little white beds. Those who remain at the school all the time are either orphans or children whose parents are destitute. Mothers who work during the day call for their children in the evening, not willing to be separated all the time. This is the case with Katherine, and Paul, and Tania. Peter is not so fortunate.

EXPRESSIONISM IN CHINESE ART

Chinese Authority's Address to Local Club

"Surprising as it may seem, the foreign residents of Shanghai have little opportunity of hearing experts on Chinese art", stated Mr. E. Kann in introducing Mr. T'eng Kuei, M.F.A., F.R.S.A., to the members of the Shanghai Art Club, on Friday evening in the new quarters in Avenue Joffre.

Mr. T'eng Kuei explained the subject of his address, "Expressionism in Chinese Art", by saying that art is a language. A language always expresses something and when it is called expressionism it means that there must be something forceful about it. Everyone receives stimuli from without. In our reactions many repeated the experience of others, while a few create something new. These are the true expressionists.

Chinese art is distinguished by the fact that it is merely suggestive, and does not tell the whole story. The thought is there, but the brush strokes are not so that the person looking at it must complete the picture. Then again the Chinese people have poise and reserve, and their own philosophic way of doing things, which is reflected in their painting. In contrast to Western art, Chinese painting is lineal, the drawing of the object and tinting the surface, while western art is the massing of different colours to make a form.

Comparisons Quoted

Mr. T'eng Kuei then dealt with lines, comparing them to all types of human beings, some muscular and powerful and abrupt, and others showing the signs of decadence. In viewing a painting, one should ask, "What is this line intended to serve, and does it fill its purpose?" There should be only enough lines to convey the thought of the picture. The modern art of Europe is too intellectual, with an over-emphasis on form, disregarding texture and losing all sentimentality. When a Chinese artist paints a tree, he must absorb its feeling, and have it penetrate his head and eye, mind and heart. On the other hand, a Chinese paints an object as he wants it to be, thus interpreting nature. This leads to the vast subject of symbolism, which gradually developed among the Chinese as they made a close study of nature. They realised that they were only a small part of this realm, and not the conquerors of nature, as the Greeks had believed. So they gave a meaning to nature, constantly symplifying, until they had mere symbols.

The Art Club has just engaged the services of Mr. T'eng Kuei as instructor in classes in Chinese painting and Western sculpture every Wednesday afternoon from three to six, which are open to members of the club with no charge. Mr. T'eng is specially well qualified to deal with these two subjects, in that he has studied extensively in the United States and Europe and has taught in the States and China. After graduating from the University of Washington, and teaching a year, he was sent to Harvard University by the Harvard-Yen Ching fellowship for graduate work, after which he spent a year in Europe on a travelling fellowship from Harvard. He returned to China where he taught at Yen Ching University in Peking, and is now on the staff of Chinan University and is giving a lecture course on Art at the University of Shanghai.

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